Retwisting the Ties that Bind

By Lisa C. Moore

INTRODUCTION

You never know what other people are dealing with. You never know how your actions may affect another person. You never know what driving forces were present during someone's childhood or formative years. You never know what deeper thoughts and intentions lurk in someone's heart and mind. Lisa C. Moore knows this better than anyone and in Retwisting the Ties that Bind, she examines these concepts as they relate to the relationship she had and has with her mother. Retwisting the Ties that Bind by Lisa C. Moore.

I do not trust my mother.

But then, she never trusted hers.

Let me be clear: I love my mother. I love who my mother is finally becoming, a more whole person than she was when I was growing up. Someone who is learning to love herself, who is finally growing up herself.

I love my mother's mind, how quick and agile and curious and cunning it can be. I love my mother's tongue, how she turns perfectly innocuous English language into

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sharp, cutting words aimed at those who do her wrong. I can only wish I was that smart, had such great timing. I'm working on it.

I love how my mother loves to play games – whether they be board games or the big boys' games – learning the ins and outs of them and becoming masterful. I'm in training to run with the big boys myself, and she takes great delight in that.

I love the elegance of my mother, how she holds her hands, the way she angles her long neck, the way she holds her head high. I admire the fullness of her lips. I think I've inherited some of these things.

But what I also seem to have inherited is a mistrust of people. Starting with my mother.

I have just finished a fantastic novel about mother-daughter-mother reincarnation. It made me cry at the end, at the daughter with the grandmother's memories, coming back to comfort the mother. I wonder at the act of taking a child in one's arms to comfort. So many women I know talk of their mothers as if their mothers are their best friends. But I can't

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recall any instance of being comforted in my mother's arms. Caged is more the feeling.

What am I missing?

Did she ever feel comforted in her mother's arms?

Trust comes from unconditional love.

I've heard stories about my grandmother. Of how she would yank elbows off the wooden edge during mealtime to teach that rule of the dinner table. She is a witty and elegant woman, and a stickler for manners, rules. I don't remember ever seeing her take my mother in her arms; physical contact was rare, save for the hello and good-bye hug. I don't remember her saying anything comforting to my mother at all, actually. When we'd visit, I remember her usual tone as more of a "you deserve what you get." I always thought it was for marrying beneath her "station in life."

My mother was not taught to love herself. She was born out of wedlock in a time when such things were a sin, a stain on the child as well as the parents. And when her sister came along later, born within the safety

4N6 Fanatics

of a marriage, the inevitable comparisons began. This much my mother has told me.

Feeling not quite "as good as," not "enough," and certainly never "better than," how can a little girl learn to love herself? I know these things are passed on.

Trust comes from feeling comfort and stability and reliability. I never turned to my mother for those things. After too much disappointment, I stopped asking early on for rides to school, from school, to anywhere. I learned how to catch the bus, and learned the inherent freedom from asking and not getting. When my mother offered to take me anywhere, I refused. I preferred the bus driver's schedule – I knew he'd be at the corner at 7:46 a.m. I asked my father for things, because sometimes things promised by my mother – money, clothes, shoes – didn't come through, and the not coming through was always at the last minute.

Did her mother not follow through on promises? Did her mother promise her anything?

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Because my mother had to work to make ends meet, I cleaned house, cooked, braided my sisters' hair, washed clothes, fed children. My mother tells a story of her father requiring that the bathroom sink be cleaned and *dried* after *every* use. She tells me this as if to say, "You don't have it that bad."

This story never comforted me.

Did she ever feel comforted? What about her mother, my grandmother? Who comforted her, told her she was loved, taught her to love herself? Who showed her, through consistent behavior, that she could rely on her mother's words and actions? Who taught her to pass it on – or not? Did she ever learn?

During my years of mothering my sister, I've learned you can't give love if you don't love yourself first, but my mother was ill equipped for the rigors of parenting. You have to give and give and give, and have enough left over to give to yourself. She didn't have that. I was lucky; I learned about consistency and reliability from my father.

A respect for boundaries yields trust.

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When I was in fifth and sixth grades, I kept a diary. Once some kids in class stole it from my purse and read it aloud to the class, snickering at my attempts at describing my body's newfound changes. I was devastated, and subsequently kept to myself in school. A few years later, in ninth grade at a new school, I took up a journal again, only to discover my mother was reading it regularly and asking me about certain passages. I gave it up for good then – at least until I was in my late twenties. She said it was the only way she would know what was going on in my head, since I didn't volunteer information. My mother's quest for knowledge about her excessively quiet daughter made me dig in my heels, learn to be secretive about private thoughts, phone calls, writing, desires.

Now I've learned to relax a little- not be on one extreme or the other. But little things still trigger the mistrust, such as my sister looking through my mail and asking who the sender is, borrowing something without asking, or even just asking. Any semblance of what I consider too much curiosity is cause for alarm.

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Did her mother respect her boundaries? Were any set?

Lack of trust yields an incomplete sense of self.

A memory: of talking to my younger teenage sister, who still lived at home, while she detailed the latest hurt from my mother. But my sister reacted, talked back, something I never dared do. I kept repeating, "You said that to her?" And she kept saying, "Yeah! Who does she think she is? I wouldn't do that to her!" I sat there amazed at my sixteen-year-old sister's womanish audacity, defying authority.

After I hung up, I had a sudden memory of me being awakened in the middle of the night by my mother. I may have been about ten. She shook me awake, told me to get my ass up, why didn't I finish cleaning the kitchen, "You left dishes in the sink." She was tired, and yelling; I was stunned at the vehemence of her words. "I work all day for you, and I come home and can't even get y'all to keep the house clean! What good are you? HUH?" And I slowly began to walk to the kitchen to

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wash the offending dishes. I don't remember crying. I do remember feeling wooden.

But some twenty years later, I have burst into tears, crying at the fact that I never remember feeling angry. And I feel incredibly angry now, angry like my sister did. Questioning, like my sister had. Sad. And thinking, what other parts of my childhood did I lose? How many memories have I blocked because I wasn't allowed to feel, to express my feelings?

I'm sure my mother has a different memory, if she has one at all.

But my mother has told me her memories of me learning to read at age three. Me crawling out onto the roof of the house as a baby, how scared she had been to come upstairs to check on me in my crib and find that I had crawled out of the window next to the crib and onto the roof.

I try to imagine the terror of a new mother finding her child sitting with a few of New Orleans, with the protective crib sides down. I can't do it.

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There are some good things. Because lack of trust produces an almost paralyzing fear of the unknown – having no control over what's going to happen – I've had to force myself to take great leaps of faith, like publishing a book, starting grad school, moving to new cities where I don't know a soul, traveling by myself, being comfortable with being alone. Having to depend on me, myself, and I. Learning to love myself. I am learning to trust my intuition.

My mother admires this about me, says she is proud of me, wishes she could do the same.

When will she learn?

I do not trust my mother.

But I am working on building an adult relationship with her, which is what I'm hoping for. It's a slow process. My instincts run counter to it. The childhood I'm rebuilding for myself doesn't include her. I am rediscovering emotions I never thought I'd own, like playfulness, anger. But we have learned to dance around my childhood and hers, and are coming to grips with being adult black women who are irrevocably tied to one another.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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